Whose Contribution Counts?

Generative AI, Cultural Participation and Collective Authorship in Research-Creation

Roman Jahandideh

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Joint Graduate Program in Communication & Culture, York University

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Summary

I am an artistic practitioner and researcher working through research-creation. Trained in architecture and landscape architecture, I now build interactive 3D and game environments and study them with participants in human–computer interaction research. This project asks how generative artificial intelligence (GenAI), meaning the models, the interfaces and the platforms that own them, is reorganizing who takes part in cultural production, whose contributions become visible and who holds authority over shared meaning. Its central question is: *how does collaborative artistic practice with GenAI redistribute participation, cultural voice and authorship, and how can research-creation make those redistributions visible and contestable?* Three subquestions ask how tools, defaults and facilitation translate, standardize or misread culturally situated contributions; how participants negotiate recognition, refusal, credit and responsibility among themselves, the group, me, the models and the platforms; and what protocols and artistic forms emerge that might support more accountable and culturally plural cultural production. The design has five linked phases: my own studio inquiry with a selected ecology of GenAI and non-AI tools; pilot consultations with four to six practitioners; a series of collaborative workshops with about 18–24 adult artists, performers, designers and creative technologists in three cohorts, in which I conduct participant observation; semi-structured focus groups with each cohort; and the co-creation of a large collaborative artwork proposed for exhibition at York University's Markham Campus. The project would contribute a communication-and-culture account of how GenAI mediation redistributes recognition and creative authority, a research-creation method for studying it, and an artwork and protocols that make those relations perceptible in public.

1 Introduction

GenAI now stands between many people and the means of cultural production. A phrase becomes an image, a hummed line an arrangement, a sketch a rendered scene. Each conversion is made by systems whose training data, defaults, moderation rules and ownership are set elsewhere, largely by platform companies, and are seldom open to the people whose contributions they transform. I therefore treat GenAI not as a neutral tool or an autonomous artist but as part of a cultural infrastructure that also includes interfaces, access conditions, hidden labour, institutions, facilitators and participants' own cultural knowledge (Crawford, 2021).

Three connected issues give this infrastructure its stakes. First, interpretive and creative authority is concentrating in opaque, proprietary platforms. Richards (2025, 276) argues that the "safe and helpful" generative assistant functions "as a proxy for authority" that delineates what its users can know and do. Caines (2026, 187–188, 194) found that rising subscription costs, uneven privacy tiers and opacity shaped what she and her students could make, and Caines and Watson (2023, 267) describe a project whose success or failure lay "completely in the hands of the corporations that designed the software". Second, GenAI can standardize and misrecognize culturally situated expression. South Asian participants found that text-to-image models reproduced an outsider's gaze on their cultures (Qadri et al., 2023); AI writing suggestions moved Indian writers toward Western styles (Agarwal et al., 2025); and stories written with model-generated ideas were rated more creative individually but grew more alike collectively (Doshi and Hauser, 2024). These findings concern particular models and tasks, not GenAI as a whole. Third, creative labour is extracted unequally: image generators are trained on artists' work without their consent, with reported economic and reputational harm to those artists (Jiang et al., 2023). Environmental cost, misinformation and job loss form the wider context (Caines, 2026, 182), which this study does not investigate empirically.

Participation and authorship matter because they are where these relations become practical. They show who can make meaning with these systems, whose contribution becomes visible, who can refuse a model's reading, who receives credit and who answers for the work once it circulates publicly. One mechanism anchors the empirical work: a system's technical record of who supplied what need not match how collaborators recognize one another, so credit can come apart from influence and responsibility. A small qualitative study cannot measure GenAI's effect on society. Situated research-creation can make broad processes observable in specific collaborative encounters and generate concepts that transfer analytically, not statistically, to other settings.

2 Objectives

2.1 Research problem and questions

Central question. How does collaborative artistic practice with generative AI redistribute participation, cultural voice and authorship, and how can research-creation make those redistributions visible and contestable?

SQ1. *Translation.* How do different GenAI tools, interfaces, model defaults and facilitation arrangements translate, amplify, standardize, misread or pass over participants' culturally situated contributions? (Studio records; workshop episodes; prompts and outputs.)

SQ2. *Negotiation.* How do participants negotiate recognition, refusal, credit, ownership and responsibility among individual contributors, the group, me as artist-facilitator, the models and the platforms behind them? (Episodes; group-authored rules; focus groups.)

SQ3. *Forms and protocols.* What collaborative protocols and artistic forms emerge through the workshops and the public artwork, and what do they suggest about more accountable and culturally plural GenAI-mediated cultural production, including where not using GenAI is the better choice? (Scores; artwork iterations; focus groups.)

None of these assumes that more provenance, more individual control or more AI improves collaboration. Refusal, ambiguity, silence, failure and non-use are treated as meaningful outcomes.

2.2 Theoretical perspective

The framework connects three bodies of work, each tied to one scale of analysis.

Participation as power (interactional scale). Jenkins and colleagues define a participatory culture as one in which "members believe their contributions matter, and feel some degree of social connection with one another" (Jenkins et al., 2006, 3). Carpentier (2016) asks more: whether participants share power at the moments when decisions are made, which separates participation from access and interaction. Bishop (2012) cautions that participatory art is too often judged by ethical rather than artistic criteria. Together they let me ask when a contribution is merely received by a model and when its maker shapes what the group does with it, without treating participation as good in itself.

Mediation and infrastructure (institutional and platform scale). Suchman (2007) shows that agency is figured and attributed in situated practice rather than residing in humans or machines. AI-mediated communication research describes models that modify messages between people (Han-

cock et al., 2020); in collective art the message becomes shared work, and the system modifying it belongs to a company that presents itself as a mere "platform" while shaping the terms by which it is judged (Gillespie, 2010). Terms of service, opacity, gallery conventions and my facilitation also distribute visibility and decisions.

Collective production and recognition (cultural scale). Becker (1982) treats art as the work of a cooperative network organized by conventions, which decide whose contribution counts as artistic. Hodson (2019, 32) shows that even when design is opened to citizens and clients, "the story is still told in terms of design-led collaboration". Model defaults may work in a comparable way, deciding whose styles become legible and whose labour disappears into "the AI".

Research-creation and critical improvisation hold these scales together. Research-creation makes the making a way of knowing (Chapman and Sawchuk, 2012) and can challenge the norms of the fields it crosses (Loveless, 2019, 37, quoted in Caines and Watson, 2023, 255). Caines treats improvisation as a method built on "real-time decision-making with others, surprise, supported and accountable risk taking, deep listening, and … the reconfiguration of mistake" (Caines and Watson, 2023, 273; see also Caines, 2021), and reads her own GenAI work as "a kind of critical improvisation practice" marked by "a constant cycle of navigating power, adaptation, surprise, failure, and creation" (Caines, 2026, 193). I ask how that cycle plays out among many people whose material is one another's offers.

2.3 Expected contribution and originality

The study aims to contribute at five levels without presuming its findings. *Conceptually*, it would offer a communication-and-culture account of how GenAI mediation redistributes recognition, cultural voice, creative authority and responsibility in collective art-making. *Empirically*, it would show how participants negotiate transformations, defaults, refusals and credit across changing tools. *Methodologically*, it combines studio inquiry, participant observation, focus groups, episode analysis and public co-creation. *Artistically*, it would produce a substantial collaborative artwork and documented scores and protocols that materialize its questions. *Practically*, it would propose situated principles for collaborative GenAI art on consent, refusal, attribution, accessibility, platform choice and shared governance, not universal design rules. Its originality lies not in new software but in following the same contributions across studio, workshop, focus group and exhibition. The significance reaches beyond one artwork: cultural participation is increasingly mediated by systems whose training sources, defaults, moderation rules and ownership are not equally visible or contestable, and a workshop and gallery offer a bounded site where those relations can be experienced, negotiated and interpreted.

3 Methods and sources

3.1 Research methods

The project follows the program's research-creation option: a substantial creative work and a 150–200-page written dissertation that carries the theoretical argument (Joint Graduate Program in Communication & Culture, 2021). Its five phases overlap and feed back into one another (Figure 1).

Phase 1: Studio inquiry and tool ecology. Before any participants are involved, I will undertake a sustained period of my own artistic research into collaboration and GenAI. I will select three or four tool families, for example text, image, voice or audio, and spatial media integrated through Unity, against explicit criteria: artistic relevance, cost and access, data and privacy terms, whether inputs and outputs can be documented, degree of user control, known cultural defaults and feasibility. Where quality allows, one will be a locally run open-weight model, and non-AI processes stay in the ecology. The phase produces experiments, scores, a failure log, a reflexive journal and preliminary works, and reads interface documentation, terms of service and model cards as cultural documents. It asks how each tool structures prompting, refusal and authorship; it is not software benchmarking.

Phase 2: Consultation and pilots. Four to six adult artists, improvisers, facilitators or creative technologists will act as advisors in pilot sessions that refine scores, access provisions, tool choices and consent and credit protocols. They are not main participants, and I will call them co-researchers only if they share decisions and credit.

Phase 3: Collaborative workshops. The provisional sample is 18–24 adults in three cohorts of six to eight: artists, performers and improvisers, designers, creative technologists and community-engaged arts practitioners. Open calls to arts communities in Toronto and York Region and to AMPD networks, excluding anyone I teach, will seek variation in discipline, GenAI experience, adult age and cultural and linguistic background; the sample is not representative. I begin with adults because the work is public, consent and authorship are complex to negotiate, and the platforms' data practices are contested. Six to eight people can make work together and be observed closely; three cohorts allow cross-case comparison. The scale rests on information power, meaning a specific sample, an established framework and repeated, dense encounters (Malterud et al., 2016), not on statistical power or declared saturation (Braun and Clarke, 2021).

Each cohort will attend four connected workshops of about two and a half hours. The sequence, set after Phases 1 and 2, will include: agreeing group conventions and making together without assuming AI is needed; experiments with more than one form of GenAI mediation and with AI/non-AI combinations; repeated chances to accept, revise, reroute, refuse, remove or reinterpret outputs; collective rules for attribution, data use, credit, reuse and decisions; reflection on misreading, stan-

dardization, surprise, exclusion and productive failure; and movement toward materials and scores for the final artwork. I will conduct disclosed participant observation with field notes and the reflexive journal. With consent, I will collect recordings, prompts and outputs, version histories, logs, artifacts and group-authored rules. A log records system events, not intentions.

Phase 4: Focus groups. Each cohort will then join one semi-structured focus group of 60–90 minutes on voice, recognition, cultural legibility, the authority of models and platforms, ownership, responsibility, refusal, access and desired changes. Focus groups make participants' interaction part of the data (Kitzinger, 1994). Short individual follow-ups are offered only to those who need a private way to discuss disagreement or power.

Phase 5: Co-creation and exhibition. The workshops lead toward a large collaborative artwork proposed for the first-floor Art Gallery at York's Markham Campus, which has shown creative-technologies exhibitions (York University Markham Campus, 2024), subject to supervisory, venue, resource, ethics and participant approval. Its form (projection, spatial sound, interactive 3D media, performance or installation) will emerge from the workshops. It should make the research perceptible, not illustrate findings, for instance by exposing traces of rejection, model defaults and contested credit. Participants decide whether and how their material, names, voices and images appear; consent to exhibit is separate from consent to research, and no audience data will be collected. For examination, the work will be documented through installation records, executable media where feasible, scores, process records and an annotated account of its iterations.

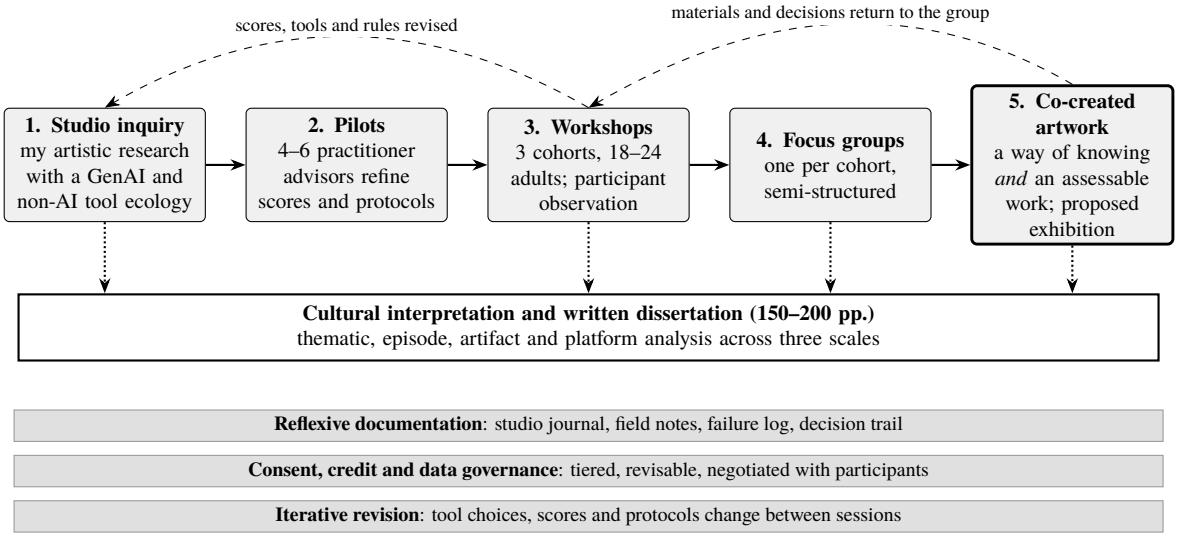


Figure 1: Proposed research-creation design. Solid arrows show the sequence of phases, dashed arrows feedback, and dotted arrows evidence moving into interpretation; grey bands run across every phase.

Analysis combines four strands: reflexive thematic analysis of focus groups and follow-ups (Braun and Clarke, 2019); multimodal analysis of selected workshop episodes, adapting the video mi-

croethnography McArthur (2015) used for interface interaction; analysis of artifacts, prompts, outputs, revisions, refusals and scores, charting each version of the artwork against the contributors who shaped it, after the version timelines of Hodson (2019, 10); and critical reading of how platform conditions and my own choices shaped what was possible. An episode runs from a contribution through its transformation and the group's response to the next creative action. Selection will include routine uptake, non-response, refusal, conflict, misrecognition and unexpected collective invention, and each episode is read against its institutional and cultural conditions. Focus-group themes and episodes are interpreted together; neither counts as the true account. Triangulation, analytic memos, a decision trail and discrepant cases support rigour. The design cannot isolate "the effect of AI" from facilitation, platform, group history and institution, and the tools will change during the study, so claims will be situated and analytically transferable, not causal.

Consent will be separate, ongoing and revisable (Strengers et al., 2021) for workshop participation, recording, processing by third-party AI services, use of quotations and artifacts, public exhibition, identifiable credit and later dissemination. Every activity has a manual, non-AI route, and anyone may refuse a tool or output without losing their place. No sensitive personal data will go to commercial services; I will prefer local or institutionally approved tools, disclose that providers may retain prompts and outputs under their current terms, and review tool choices at ethics approval, as Caines did when weighing privacy tiers against cost (Caines, 2026, 187–188). Workshops will distinguish technical provenance, legal ownership, public credit and felt authorship, and discuss copyright and training-data uncertainty openly. Groups will agree in advance on the limits of withdrawal once shared material has been exhibited. Credit will be negotiated; I will seek funding for honoraria but do not assume it. I will attend to power between myself and participants and between more and less technically experienced participants, and support visual, sonic, physical, linguistic and technical participation, with alternatives to sound-only or vision-only interaction and help at every level of AI literacy. When models misread culturally specific expression, participants will not be asked to perform trauma or to educate me. Participation alone does not make the project equitable (Birhane et al., 2022).

3.2 Sources

Primary sources are those generated in the five phases described above, together with interface documentation, terms of service and model cards. Secondary sources are discussed in Section 4.

3.3 Anticipated problems of access

Three problems of access are foreseeable. *Participants:* recruitment depends on open calls; if a cohort cannot complete the series, its completed sessions remain usable as a smaller case and a replacement cohort will be considered. *Venue:* the Markham Campus gallery is a proposal, not a commitment; if it is unavailable, the work will be presented in another campus space or as a documented installation for examination. *Tools:* platforms may close, change terms or prices, or update models during the study, so Phase 1 keeps substitutes, including a local model, and records each tool's version as part of the evidence.

4 Relationship to existing literature and professional practice

I come to this question as a practitioner. Architecture at Tabriz Islamic Art University and landscape architecture at Istanbul Technical University taught me to treat designed environments as media of social life: thresholds, paths and light shape who gathers, who is seen and how people move together. In ITU's Virtual Landscape Lab I studied how people perceive mediated environments (Jahandideh et al., 2023). My current master's in Interactive Arts and Technology at Simon Fraser University, in Steve DiPaola's iViz Lab, moved this practice into interactive 3D and game environments: I build multiplayer worlds and physiological interfaces in Unity and C#, use image-generation models in design work, and study these systems with participants. One study is accepted at ACM ISS 2026 (Jahandideh et al., 2026); another is under revision (Jahandideh, 2026). The through-line runs from designing spaces, to designing mediated environments, to asking who controls how a technical system represents and translates people: in the teammate study, participants accepted a shared heart-rate cue only if they controlled who saw it. As artist, system designer, facilitator, participant observer and analyst, I will hold power over what participants can do and how their actions are read, so documenting my own decisions is part of the method.

My lineage is spatial and interactive rather than drawn from an AI-art canon, but six practices shape this project's questions and decisions. Anna Ridler's *Myriad (Tulips)* (2018) exhibits thousands of tulip photographs she took and labelled by hand, making the labour and subjective classification inside a dataset into the artwork (Ridler, 2018). It leads me to treat prompts, labels and rejected outputs as exhibitable material; I depart from it by making that labour collective and contested. Sougwen Chung's *Drawing Operations* pairs her drawing with robotic systems, including one trained on her archived drawings and gestures (Chung, 2014). It models co-creative performance between one artist and a system shaped by her hand; my workshops involve many hands. Stephanie Dinkins's *Not the Only One* is trained on oral histories from three generations of women in her family and

hosted locally to protect community data (Dinkins, 2018). It makes culturally situated data and its custody an artistic choice, which informs my tool criteria. Holly Herndon and Mat Dryhurst's *The Call* recorded fifteen community choirs to train choral models and tested a data trust between contributors and model users (Herndon and Dryhurst, 2024). It is the closest precedent for governing collective voice, but its governance was designed by the artists and institution, whereas my workshops ask participants to negotiate rules themselves. In Lauren Lee McCarthy's *LAUREN* the artist performs as a human smart-home assistant, exposing the labour hidden inside automation (McCarthy, 2017); as facilitator, I may be that hidden human. Caines's *multiPLAY* explored digital community engagement with Canadian improvisers through workshops, open studios and an artist hackathon (Caines, 2019), a model for improvised making across media. Jennifer Walshe's insistence that "AI is not a singular phenomenon" (Walshe, 2023) underwrites the multi-tool design.

The project belongs to Technology in Practice because it examines critically how GenAI platforms, interfaces and institutional conditions configure cultural practice, and to Media & Culture because it studies cultural production, representation, participation, authorship and labour. It answers the program's aim of "promoting the application of critical theory and research" (Joint Graduate Program in Communication & Culture, 2026a) and its PhD objectives, which name "creative exhibitions" among the routes to independent research (Joint Graduate Program in Communication & Culture, 2026b), while keeping the written dissertation as the site of sustained argument. Dr. Caines's work on critical improvisation, socially responsive creative technologies and GenAI is its closest ground; her GenAI study focused mostly on course and workshop design (Caines, 2026, 176); this project asks how culturally situated contributions and authorship are negotiated in sustained collective art-making and then made public. How it might relate to her SSHRC Insight project, *Interfacing, Playtesting, Resetting* (Goodfellow Craig, 2026), or to her other case studies would be designed with her later; nothing here assumes access, participants, funding or a venue.

5 Proposed chapter outline

1. GenAI and cultural participation.
2. Participation, mediation and collective production.
3. Methodology: research-creation, studio, workshops and reflexivity.
4. The studio inquiry and the tool ecology as cultural document.
5. Translation, recognition and refusal in the workshops.
6. Credit, responsibility and the public artwork.
7. Protocols and wider stakes.

6 Proposed timeline

Dates assume full-time study from Fall 2027.

Jan–Apr 2029	Proposal approval; ethics application; Phase 1 studio inquiry continues.
May–Aug 2029	Phase 2 consultations and pilots.
Sep 2029–Apr 2030	Phase 3 workshops with three cohorts; Phase 4 focus groups.
May–Dec 2030	Phase 5 co-creation and proposed exhibition; analysis.
Jan–Jun 2031	Writing and revision of chapters.
Jul–Aug 2031	Submission and defence (Year 5 in reserve).

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